

BANASTHALI VIDYAPITH, TONK IN THE LAND OF WOMEN

As one crosses an old entrance gate after driving down a single-lane road, 7 km off the National Highway 12, in Tonk district, 72 km south of Jaipur, the sight of a lush green campus and hundreds of girls in khadi, carrying umbrellas and walking in unison, greets you. The sprawling campus houses 6,800 girls; while another 1,200 girls stay in the extended campus in Jaipur. Quite an achievement for an institute which started as a

CAN DO IT: Shastri with students



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

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girls take flight training in the campus every year.

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hostels, the entire number, are named after Shanta, the daughter of founders Ratan and Hira Lal Shastri. At the age of 12, she made 1,000 mud bricks for a school room.

residential school for girls in 1935 with only five students. Over a lakh girls have graduated since then from Banasthali Vidyapith, a deemed university for women. Most of the students come from the Hindi belt. A third of them are from Rajasthan, that too from remote areas. The medium of instruction in the school section is Hindi and in the higher classes also it's predominantly Hindi.

Over the years, the institute has become a centre that focuses on professional courses to prepare women for the corporate world. "It aims to be a place where girls attain academic

excellence along with household skills and even master so-called masculine skills like riding, shooting and even using lathis," says Vice-Chancellor Aditya Shastri. The institute has its own flying club—a Cessna Skyhawk has been just unpacked from a box and two more are arriving soon—and shooting range.

There is a touching story behind the flight training. The aircraft wing is managed by Captain Sohil Handa, a pilot who lost his eyesight in a forced landing almost a decade ago while saving all on board. The university decided to avail of his experience. Every year 50 students undergo the flying training while many others opt for riding at its equestrian field or shooting. Apart from these, the university offers computer application courses from which every year 2,000 girls pass out. The first batch of B.Tech students will be passing out next year.

An institute rooted to Gandhian values, the Vidyapith has adapted itself to the needs of the new economy, and even strives for self-reliance. When the government once decided to freeze its grant at Rs 3 crore for an annual budget of Rs 5 crore, the institute started exploring new avenues and soon stopped taking government aid. Today, for an annual budget of Rs 50 crore, it has joined hands with corporates like Mahindra and Mahindra, ICICI Bank

"Here girls attain academic excellence while mastering skills like riding, shooting."

ADITYA SHASTRI, VICE-CHANCELLOR, BANASTHALI VIDYAPITH

and Artech Infosystems to set up new centres of learning. Of course, the education in the university has become expensive now. The average cost of a year's education is Rs 60,000 which includes hostel and mess fees. Despite the fees, there is always a long waiting list of admission seekers. "Every year we have at least one student from every state and Union territory of the country," says Shastri. Not surprising for an institute about which Jawaharlal Nehru once said, "If I had been a girl, I would have come to Banasthali for my education."

by Rohit Parihar